



Speak Easy

GSM offers a variety of advanced features and services that includes speech encryption, facsimile, data services and SMS. From the outset, GSM has been a system designed with stringent levels of inbuilt security. With constantly enhanced transmission protocols and algorithms added to the flexible platform, GSM remains a very secure wireless standard.

Enhanced Full Rate (EFR) is one of the key features in developing new markets for differentiation of speech quality between existing GSM networks and new networks that have EFR infrastructure and mobiles. EFR not only enables the GSM operator to differentiate its product from existing networks, it also allows it to compete with services as it offers a comparable speech quality.

So what exactly is EFR? It is a codec that has been defined specifically for speech quality purposes with its improved coding algorithms so that it has higher tolerance to interference.

With GSM radio, speech is converted: transferred by a mathematical algorithm into digital format, transmitted and then translated back to its original form at the receiver end. The EFR codec is particularly optimised for the natural transmission of the human language. The characteristic sound and the language melody of humans remain (the harmonics are maintained), thereby the language becomes warmer.

A majority of handsets available in the market support the EFR standard. If supported by your handset and your service provider, you can receive far better quality voice reception, at the cost of a decrease in the talk time of your phone. On the other hand if the network has the Half-Rate codec active, then there is a decrease in the voice quality with an approximate increase of 25 per cent to 30 per cent in the talk time of your phone.

We called up a leading mobile operator to find out whether they provide EFR. But they were clueless about it and we still await a response.

Ericsson T200 had GPRS support in this category. The Nokia 3610 and the 2100, which are new launches were not GPRS enabled. We hope to see more GPRS capable phones, under the Rs 8,000 price tag soon.

Extra and Miscellaneous features

The mobile phones of today have some nifty features to show off. The Motorola C300 had the voice-command feature, where as voice-dialling is common in all Nokia phones. Adding voice tags is very easy with the Nokia phones. The voice tags were perfect, even though they were recorded in noisy environments. Surprisingly, the Sony Ericsson phones missed out completely on this feature. They also disappointed us, with support for only one phone line, which even old phones such as the Nokia 3310 have. If you are looking for the cheapest, frill-free, phone with a calculator and games, then Nokia 3310 is the best choice.

Performance

When it comes to voice clarity and picking up signals, there is no competition to a Nokia. Nokia phones have the best antenna and support electronics, which gives them excellent clarity. We tested the phones in different areas, both open air and inside buildings, and found out that there were some areas where only the Nokia phones managed to stay connected. All Nokia phones performed equally, thus you need not worry about voice clarity

when buying a Nokia. Sony Ericsson performed decently, but lacked voice clarity. These phones also failed to catch signals in building interiors. The same was the case with the Siemens and other brands. Hence, if your workplace is located far away from sunlight, as it is in many offices in the metros, a Nokia comes across as the ideal candidate.



Take that call

This comparison was mainly between Nokia, which was dominant in terms of numbers, and Sony Ericsson, which has the impressive T100 and T200. The Nokia 3310 and 3315 are showing signs of ageing, as they lack many common features, such as calendar-ing, and still sell only due to the glory they earned in the past and their lower prices. The Sony Ericsson phones are looking very competitive. The T200,

Sony Ericsson T200

Rating: A

Price: Rs 6,495

which costs less than the Nokia 3610, 2100 and even the 3350, packs more features and looks just as good. The T100, on the other hand, not only has a different look, but is equally good in performance. It is also competitively priced.

Top 5	Phone grip (out of 5)	
	Sony Ericsson T100	4
	Motorola C300	4
	Nokia 3610	3.5
	Nokia 3350	3.5
	Nokia 3315	3.5



*see on page 98-99